

work with Zoho University, where you take in people without fancy college degrees. How do you see the problem of unemployable graduates from India for the technology sector? Because today, there seems to be a big scramble for talent, which is probably why issues like moonlighting are coming to the fore. How do you see this problem and the way around it?

A: A lot of companies look at talent as something as a given that you get from the market. We see, particularly in the Indian context, the challenge is one of creating and nurturing the talent. It's a mindset shift. But we are a talent creation business, we are a talent nurturing business, not merely a talent acquisition business. So, we don't assume that there's ready-made talent available in the market. We actively seek to create and nurture the talent. That approach has been true for nearly our entire existence as a company and that has served us well. In fact, that is critical for our

“The overall premise [of the technology revolution] could be correct [and] the digital transformation would come true. But that doesn't mean all the investment dollars that bet on the premise would get a return”

growth, as well as for our rural expansion, as well as for employee loyalty. All three are driven by the fact that we invest in talent, we create and nurture the talent, and that has fuelled our growth as a company. And it has allowed us to expand, by going into rural areas with an abundance of latent talent, talent that is intrinsically there, but someone has to go and nurture it, and then bring it out. And that also promotes employee loyalty. Because when you invest in people, they tend to be loyal. So all of that has been helped by our policy of how we look at talent.

Q: Any thoughts on moonlighting? Or do you have a specific stance on it?

A: It really isn't a problem for us. But the problem in defining all this is if somebody is, for example, a really good software engineer who runs a YouTube channel on the side on cooking or organic farming... and I'm on Twitter, talking about macroeconomics—does that count as moonlighting? I read up a lot about

macroeconomics, it informs my work as the CEO of this company, but there's well beyond that. I talk about rural development [and other] topics like that. So that's why I think it's really difficult to define this. Our policy in Zoho is to use your common sense. There are some obvious ones—if you're doing some work, and then you're doing the exact same work for a competitor, and you're getting paid for it, clearly that would be violation of trust. And so that's where you just use your common sense. That's the policy.

Q: You come from fairly modest roots. You grew up in a household where your father was a stenographer in the Madras High Court. Has that kind of upbringing gone a long way in shaping the person that you are?

A: Absolutely. My value systems come from my parents. My parents retain the exact life they've had well before this success happened. That is a role model for me. If it's okay for my father to live a humble life, why shouldn't I enjoy the same kind of life, which is a very modest one? That was drilled into our heads from childhood. My parents never took on debt [even though] my father's income was modest. As a result, those values stayed with us. I'm truly blessed to have them as parents because those values are what helped me in terms of staying humble, staying close to my roots, and not getting over-excited about wealth itself. I separate the wealth from myself. It's not mine, in a sense. It allows us to do some good for our society. And I live in a rural area and I, on a daily basis, come across a lot of causes that I want to support, and I'm blessed that the wealth allows me to do that. But beyond that, I'm not personally interested in that. I would want to be a true son of my parents, which means that I cannot be flashy about displaying wealth.

Q: Would you go as far as to say that when you see businessmen with almost a crude kind of display of wealth, you find it distasteful?

A: I don't want to comment on other people. But I'll say there is an ancient philosophy from our land, which advises moderation in all things. That helps all of us because we are, in a sense, custodians of the wealth. Father of the Nation [Mohandas Karamchand] Gandhi said this. He was never a socialist, but he said that capitalism was a custodian of the wealth. And that's how I see it. Our family is merely a custodian of the wealth; we get to direct it to good causes. That's how I see it. Based on my upbringing, I cannot have extreme display of personal wealth. **BT**

This interview was taken before Zoho announced it was entering the electric vehicles segment